

OOLONG TEA

There is a wide range of oolongs available, each with different oxidation levels, aromas, and flavors. A green oolong, such as Ali Shan from Taiwan, may have a 35 percent oxidation level and a floral aroma, while a Wuyi Rock could have an 80 percent oxidation level and rich, roasted, earthy notes.

Oolongs are among the most difficult teas to produce, as their quality depends on the skill of their producer. Although this semi-oxidized tea literally takes a beating during processing, oolong is very forgiving, and can be used for multiple infusions, presenting new flavors each time.

PREPARATION GUIDELINES

Tea shown here: Ali Shan oolong, from Ali mountain, Nantou, Taiwan

Measure: 2 tsp for $\frac{3}{4}$ cup water.

Water temperature: 185°F (85°C) for lightly oxidized oolongs; 200°F (95°C) for heavily oxidized oolongs.

Infusion: Warm the steeping vessel first, and rinse the leaves with hot water before steeping for 1-2 minutes. Increase steeping time by 1 minute for each subsequent infusion. May be used for up to 10 infusions.



DRY LEAVES

The medium to dark jade green leaves of this lightly oxidized oolong are rolled into tight balls, some retaining their stems.



WET LEAVES

With each infusion, the leaves unfurl to reveal large, thick, shiny leaves with redness around the edges (indicating where the oxidation occurred).



LIQUOR

The bright yellow liquor is sweet and fragrant, and has slight citrus and floral notes. Each subsequent infusion reveals new flavors.